

Chapter 63_1: Gift

Ning Fuyi didn't hear clearly. When she pricked up her ears again, Chu Qingqiu had already passed by her, walking with hands clasped behind her back toward the commotion.

The place of commotion was the ancient well the woman had mentioned. The well opening was about half a zhang¹ wide, already dried up inside. For some unknown reason, it hadn't been filled in yet. The real empress had been thrown inside and was now being pulled out. Dozens of imperial physicians surrounded her, frantically bustling about as they placed her in a sedan chair to carry her back to the palace quarters.

After rounds of treatment by the palace's imperial physicians and the Liu family's medical immortals, they finally confirmed that the empress was unharmed, and everyone finally relaxed.

Two days later, the empress awoke from her coma. After hearing about what had happened, she expressed endless gratitude. Chu Qingqiu and the others declined her thanks, and when she brought out countless mortal treasures to give them, they all politely refused as well.

However, when those treasures were presented to Ning Fuyi, she looked at a jade bracelet carved with gardenia flowers and fell into contemplation. Finally, she declined the other chests of jewels and only kept this bracelet.

Seeing that the empress had awakened and there was no more demonic qi in the palace, Ning Fuyi and the others set out on their return journey.

However, the empress remained deeply grateful to everyone from Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate for working together to rescue her. She specifically mobilized the entire nation's strength to hold a grand immortal dedication ceremony, praying for blessings and giving thanks to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate. At the same time, she granted a general amnesty throughout the country and celebrated for several days before finally stopping.

Such a grand display of gratitude naturally reached the ears of various immortal sects. Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's reputation soared, and its influence in the martial world seemed to be surpassing even that of Tianji Sword Sect².

So when Ning Fuyi and the others returned riding White Lin, they saw all the elders leading the sect's vast number of disciples, standing in formation before Cloud Deep Hall³ to welcome them.

Chu Qingqiu hadn't expected that empress to be so extravagant, so she hadn't given any instructions beforehand. Now, seeing the large characters "Congratulations on the Divine Venerable's Return" that Elder Yuanming had written in mid-air, her already poor expression turned even more sour.

Her mood had been low these past few days, causing both Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu to not dare approach her. Qiu Yi, who knew she had caused trouble, was the most restless. Usually unable to keep calm, she had surprisingly remained silent for two or three days straight, even more obedient than the silly White Lin.

Fortunately, although Chu Qingqiu was cold, she wasn't willful. She didn't disappoint the good intentions of the elders and sect disciples, landing amidst all the fanfare.

"We pay our respects to the Divine Venerable." Thousands of disciples stood in formation before the hall, their voices like mountain bells, shaking the earth and causing birds to take flight for hundreds of li⁴ around.

Elder Yuanming approached with a beaming smile: "Divine Venerable! Today the sect has prepared a banquet. We hope the Divine Venerable will consider joining the disciples for some relaxation?"

Chu Qingqiu really couldn't bear to look at those large characters above her head, so she waved her hand to dismiss them before speaking: "It's just a small matter. Why make such a public announcement?"

"Ah, Divine Venerable, you're wrong about that. Our Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's strength can't compare to the top sects to begin with. After the former sect master's passing, it's been even worse, so our position among the Six Sects has been precarious. The Qi Kingdom matter may be small, but the reputation is huge!"

"Besides, today isn't just to welcome you alone, Divine Venerable. It happens that disciples who went out to subdue demons are gradually returning. For dozens of days straight, everyone's been living frugally. This is a perfect opportunity to let the disciples rest. Why not?"⁵ Elder Yuanming said, waving his folding fan cheerfully.

Chu Qingqiu reluctantly accepted his explanation and spoke again: "The Qi Kingdom matter wasn't accomplished by this venerable alone, but also by several juniors. Please reward them as well, Elder."

Everyone's gaze immediately fell on the three people she gestured toward - Ning Fuyi, Liu Wenzhu, and Qiu Yi standing side by side. For a moment, there was envy all around, making the three quite uncomfortable, especially the thin-skinned Liu Wenzhu, whose face turned as red as a persimmon.

"Naturally." Elder Yuanming smiled and turned around. Elder Pingyao, who was usually stern-faced, actually relaxed her expression considerably and nodded to him.

The only one who remained stiff was Mei Chensi. Although he wore a smile on his face, there was no hint of mirth in his eyes.

After all, he had already ordered not to pursue the Qishan matter, never expecting that it would now be discovered that there really were demons causing trouble. This was a real slap in the face, and the ones who achieved merit were Chu Qingqiu and Ning Fuyi. How could he not be angry?

But no matter how resentful he felt inside, he didn't dare show it openly. He could only smile and offer congratulations.

Chu Qingqiu nodded coldly and followed everyone into the hall, which made Mei Chensi so angry he nearly ground his silver teeth to powder.

Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate wasn't actually as strict with sect rules as Tianji Sword Sect. The disciples of Tianji Sword Sect were all like ascetic monks, abstaining from play and even forbidden from touching wine and meat.

But Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate was completely different - loose sect rules and free-spirited. Especially when Ning Changfeng was alive, he would set out wine and immortal fruits every few days, letting the sect disciples enjoy themselves to their hearts' content. In Ning Changfeng's words, cultivation was about improving techniques and virtue, not about being pure-hearted and ascetic, so he never restricted the sect disciples much.

After Ning Changfeng's death, this was the first time for such relaxation.

On the steps sat the various elders and sect masters. In the vast open space before the hall, numerous low tables appeared out of thin air. Disciples from various courtyards sat in small groups, chattering about their experiences subduing demons and eliminating evil these past days. After three rounds of wine, they became even more uninhibited, putting their arms around each other's shoulders and playing word games⁶.

The North Courtyard disciples sat together in one area. Several were already dead drunk, collapsed under tables in sleep, and were carried away by nearby immortal attendants. New disciples filled their spots and continued drinking and gaming.

Beside her, Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin were already lying motionless on the table. Ning Fuyi had also been forced by that girl with the sky-high braids to drink quite a bit. Even with her good alcohol tolerance, she felt somewhat dizzy and quickly claimed to be drunk to escape. But halfway through leaving, she was dragged into another crowd by several East Courtyard disciples. When she came to, her hands had been filled with another full cup of wine.

The one drunkenly embracing her was Feng Ge, who had just returned from Dongyue. Her drunken appearance lacked her usual propriety. With her long legs propped on a seat, she was quite unrestrained, slamming a wine pot in front of Ning Fuyi and slurring: "Everyone! This is our junior sister Hu Yi! I treated her poorly before, but from now on, she's my sister Feng Ge's blood sister!"

"Sister!" Several East Courtyard disciples who rarely showed their faces normally shouted along, then began drinking crosswise⁷ in pairs.

"Although you don't have much talent!" Feng Ge continued, swaying her head. "Your character isn't bad. Before, this senior sister misunderstood you. Senior sister will punish herself with a drink!"

Saying this, she grabbed the wine from Ning Fuyi's hand and drained it in one gulp. Though her words didn't sound very pleasant, they were sincere. Ning Fuyi could only cover her lips and cough, somewhat amused and exasperated.

At this moment, she suddenly felt a sharp pain in her back. Pretending to turn around, she used her peripheral vision to look toward the source of the pain. In the crowd diagonally behind her sat Li Chao'an, gripping a wine cup tightly in her hands, her gaze coldly and venomously fixed on Ning Fuyi's back.

Ning Fuyi calmly turned back around, extracted her arm from Feng Ge's embrace (who was now nodding off with her head on the table), pretended to be drunk, and swayed as she left the gathering.

Li Chao'an didn't follow, nor did she continue watching her. Ning Fuyi left the banquet alone, took a detour, and walked back to the small wooden house Ning Changfeng had given her.

She crossed the barrier and entered. Having not returned for a long time, there were no traces of others having set foot here. She pulled out a sheet of rice paper from the books on the table and used ink to draw an extremely complex formation.

This formation was called "Earth Immortal Treasure Seeking." In the past when she had demonic power, Ning Fuyi often used this formation to summon lonely souls and wild ghosts to do things for her. These ghosts generally wandered the human world for years, forgetting their past lives with empty minds, obedient and useful like puppets.

But now she had no demonic power, so she didn't know if the formation would still work.

After drawing the last stroke, she summoned immortal power from her fingertips and poured it in. The ink immediately rose into the air, forming a magical array in mid-air.

Ning Fuyi closed her eyes, waiting for the cold wind around her to appear. However, after a long while, she didn't feel any chill on her back. Instead, her nose caught a rich floral fragrance.

She tentatively opened her eyes, and her heart immediately filled with shock. All her drunkenness vanished, and her spine nearly hit the bookshelf behind her. A thousand vulgar curses rose in her mind, but she only managed to curse "What the hell!"

What she had summoned weren't lonely souls and wild ghosts at all, but a group of beautiful flower fairies⁸! Each one had a delicate, small, and lovely figure with pink, tender wings, holding hands and dancing in mid-air. Countless flower petals fluttered down from the ceiling, beautiful enough to...

Make one spit blood.

Ning Fuyi stood with her mouth agape for quite a while before accepting the fact that she had summoned flower fairies. Although this kind of thing had happened many times since her rebirth, every time she saw these fantastical scenes that didn't match her nature, she still felt an impulse to destroy heaven and earth.

She exhaled and waved her hand. The other flower fairies dispersed, leaving only the most nimble one - palm-sized with brilliant pink butterfly wings on her back, her hair adorned with peach blossom pendants, emanating waves of fragrance.

"Can you conceal your aura?" Ning Fuyi asked, throwing in the towel.

The flower fairy covered her lips and nodded.

"Good. Could you help me keep watch on Li Chao'an? She's the one whose hairstyle is quite similar to yours. If she makes any unusual moves, come tell me immediately." Ning Fuyi spoke gently and kindly.

The flower fairy twisted her little bottom and flew away. Only then did Ning Fuyi sigh and burn the rice paper, heading toward Jingshan Palace⁹.

Footnotes:

¹ **Zhang (丈)** - Traditional Chinese unit of measurement, approximately 3.3 meters or 10.8 feet

² **Tianji Sword Sect (天玑剑宗)** - One of the major cultivation sects in this world, known for their strict rules

³ **Cloud Deep Hall (云深殿)** - A main hall at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate

⁴ **Li (里)** - Traditional Chinese unit of distance, approximately 500 meters

⁵ **Why not? (何乐不为)** - Chinese idiom meaning "why not do something that brings joy/benefit"

⁶ **Word games** - Likely referring to "flying flower orders" (飞花令), a traditional Chinese drinking game involving poetry

⁷ **Drinking crosswise (鸳鸯酒)** - A drinking custom where two people cross arms and drink from each other's cups

⁸ **Flower fairies (花仙)** - Magical beings in Chinese mythology, spirits of flowers who take beautiful female forms

⁹ **Jingshan Palace (静山宫)** - Chu Qingqiu's residence, literally "Quiet Mountain Palace"